

Podiceps cristatus

Great crested grebe



Length 18–20 in (46–51 cm)

Weight 1¼–3¼ lb (0.6–1.5 kg)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Partial migrant

Status Least concern

Location Europe, Asia, Africa, Australia, New Zealand



The largest grebe in Europe and northern Africa, the great crested grebe is famous for its remarkably elaborate courtship displays, which involve complex, ritualized postures, dives, and head-shaking; during the displays, its crest is raised and the tippets are flared. It often peers into the water while swimming on the surface to locate fish, then dives up



PARENTAL CARE



Parents take turns carrying the young on their backs and bringing them food. Each parent develops a preference for particular young, resulting in the adults dividing the brood in order to care exclusively for their favorites.

to 100 ft (30 m) deep. Populations of the great crested grebe declined in the mid-19th century, but have recovered with protection and an increase in man-made habitats, such as gravel pits and reservoirs.

CREST AND TIPPETS

This elegant bird is distinguished by the ornamental black crest on its crown and its elongated, chestnut and black cheek feathers (tippets).

Podiceps gallardoi

Hooded grebe



Length 13½ in (34 cm)

Weight 19 oz (525 g)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Nonmigrant

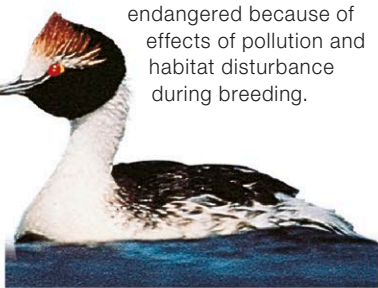
Status Critically endangered

Location S. South America



First described in 1974, this medium-sized, black and white grebe has a cinnamon and black crest and a small, pointed bill. Courtship involves a unique “sky jabbing” display in which

males and females come face to face and vigorously move their heads up and down. Populations are small, occurring on isolated lakes in remote areas of Patagonia; the species winters in sheltered bays along the Patagonian coast. It is endangered because of effects of pollution and habitat disturbance during breeding.



Podilymbus podiceps

Pied-billed grebe



Length 12–15 in (31–38 cm)

Weight 9–21 oz (250–575 g)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Partial migrant

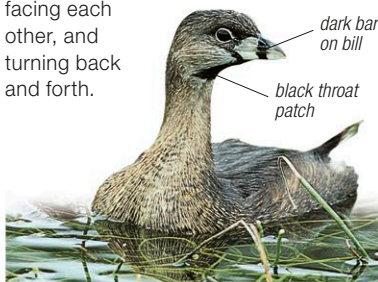
Status Least concern

Location North America, Central America, N.W. and S.E. South America



Small and stocky, with a short, arched bill, this brown and white bird is found in freshwater bodies in the breeding season, and winters in areas with open

water or in brackish estuaries. Strongly territorial and aggressive, it threatens and chases birds of the same species as well as other waterbirds. Mates may perform a “triumph ceremony” after chasing off an intruder; this involves the pair rising into an upright posture facing each other, and turning back and forth.



Aechmophorus occidentalis

Western grebe



Length 22–30 in (55–75 cm)

Weight 2¼–4½ lb (1–2 kg)

Plumage Sexes alike

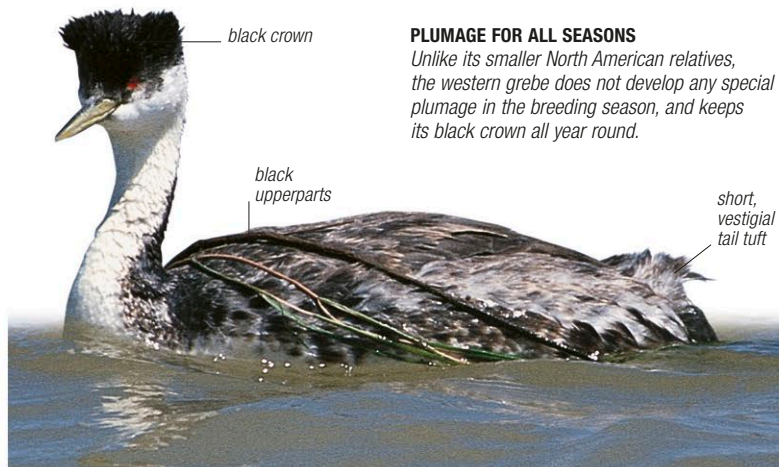
Migration Migrant

Status Least concern

Location C. and S. North America



A large grebe with black and white plumage, this bird has a long, slender neck. Mates are in close contact from pairing to taking care of the young. Both sexes build nests on water, anchored to surface plants. Parents take turns carrying young on their backs for the first 2–4 weeks, and feed them until they are 8 weeks old. At the end of the 19th century, tens of thousands of these grebes were hunted for their silky belly feathers, used in coats and hats. Populations have recovered, although they are still in danger from pollution, oil spills, habitat loss, and disturbance by humans.



COURTSHIP RUSH



This species engages in an energetic courtship, following the same rituals as the great crested grebe. The most famous display is the “rush” (shown above), in which birds run across the water side by side. If they continue to be interested in each other, they then perform the “weed dance” (see opposite), in which each bird dives for aquatic vegetation, then holds it high while turning from side to side. In established pairs, the male brings fish to his mate.

PLUMAGE FOR ALL SEASONS

Unlike its smaller North American relatives, the western grebe does not develop any special plumage in the breeding season, and keeps its black crown all year round.

Rollandia microptera

Titicaca grebe



Length 15½–18 in (39–45 cm)

Weight 22 oz (625 g)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Nonmigrant

Status Endangered

Location W. South America (Lakes Titicaca and Poopo)



From a distance, this medium-sized South American grebe looks like many of its relatives, with a crested head, brown back and flanks, and white underside. However, its wings are so small that it cannot fly. If threatened, the short-winged grebe patters across the water at speed, flapping its wings rapidly without being able to take off. This unusual bird is found primarily on 2 large lakes of the Central Andes, at an altitude of about 11,900 ft (3,600 m).

Poliiocephalus poliocephalus

Hoary-headed grebe



Length 11½–12 in (29–31 cm)

Weight 8–9 oz (225–250 g)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Nomadic

Status Least concern

Location Australia (including Tasmania), S. New Zealand



Distinguished by the “brushed back” white, hairlike plumes on its head and upper neck, this bird differs from other grebes in numerous ways. It flies more than other species of grebes, and is probably the least vocal and most social, often found in huge flocks. Courtship is relatively simple compared with that of other grebes, and the nests are typically built in shallower water. The hoary-headed grebe has a dark bill with a pale tip; the males have longer bills.